A second challenge arose as it became apparent that policies of friendship were not sufficient in ensuring security. *Rapprochement* towards China did not prevent invasion, and friendship towards the Soviet Union produced little benefit in the light of a military threat from China. Nehru lamented China's betrayal of "good faith" and attributed the attack to a Chinese foreign policy based on a stark view that the world was divided into communists and imperialists, between which war was inevitable.[15] For him, the conflict was not a consequence of non-alignment but rather proved that India must be prepared to fend off hostility from other nations by building up its defence capabilities, which in the short term would require assistance from other countries. For many members of Parliament, however, the future value of non-alignment was dubious, and members from opposition parties and Congress alike voiced support for India's attachment to the US-led military bloc.[16]

These challenges ultimately did not terminate India's commitment to non-alignment but did begin to redefine it. Recognising the limits of friendship, Nehru increased defence spending as part of India's development objectives. In addition to American pledges, India garnered support from the United Kingdom, Canada, France, and Australia and increased defence imports from the Soviet Union.[17] New Delhi applied these procurements to its 1964 rearmament plan with an eye on building up defences against the Chinese threat, which intensified with China's first nuclear test in 1964, while also working to resolve the Kashmir dispute with Pakistan as part of a broader effort to assure President Ayub Khan that rearmament was not a measure of hostility towards Pakistan.[18] In a broader sense, the shock of the war showed that India could no longer fully avoid taking sides. Domestic limitations meant that substantial external support was necessary for security.